Mohini Mohan Pal and others who fought back were allegedly implicated in cases of rape and attempt to murder.

Land in Rambhadrapur village, where much of the illegal takeover is said to have happened, is very fertile, yielding three crops a year. Only 25 per cent of farmers/ landowners, who see farming as a loss-making proposition, agreed to lease their land. For them, the promoters' offer of a 15-year lease for an annual rent of Rs 60,000-65,000 approximated to their yearly income. But those dependent on farming as a livelihood say annual profit from their three-crop land is between Rs 80,000 and Rs 1 lakh. "There is no question of giving away land when farming is profitable. Landowners at the mercy of hired tillers might have surrendered. But they are few," says Tulsi Pal, a farmer and secretary of Krishi o Krishak Bachao (Save Farming and Farmers) Committee, which was formed in 2019 to fight against the alleged land grab.

Farmers spearheading the movement say they faced hooligans armed with bombs who laid siege to the land between January and May 2022. "Twenty-five of us were badly injured and had to be hospitalised. After a while, the police did lodge an FIR, but no arrests were made," alleges Pramanik. Villagers say they arranged all-night vigils to protect their land. "But what can we do against mercenary anti-socials who set fire to our fields and threatened us at gunpoint? No help came from the police," says Pal. The officer-in-charge of Sabang police station, however, says that seven FIRs were lodged and five people arrested.

FARMERS SAY THE LANDGRABBERS SET FIRE TO FIELDS AND SPOILT CROPS BY SPRAYING INSECTICIDES



LAST STAND
Members of the farmers' protest committee say they will 'give blood, but not land'

Unable to get help, farmers moved court. Their first petition was filed on March 25, 2021, and the HC division bench under Chief Justice Prakash Shrivastava and Justice Rajarshi Bharadwaj ordered the district magistrate to provide the necessary security to the farmers. District land reforms officer Joy Banerjee visited the site as directed by the court and found six inches of soil removed. "The digging was done with a clear intention of practising pisciculture and I gave a note on the basis of the court order that no conversion (of farmland into fisheries) can take place without permission of the department concerned," says Banerjee. After this, too, had no effect, the committee filed applications for contempt of court in January and March 2022. It alleges that poisonous chemicals and saltwater were used to damage the land. "Insecticides were sprayed on paddy ready for harvest. Water from adjacent fish ponds was pumped in. And they rendered 90 per cent of tubewells defunct. Farmers faced huge losses and had no choice but to depend on land sharks to bail them out. Once that happened, there was no way land could be reclaimed," says Narayan Manna, who owns over an acre.

The TMC-controlled panchayat, however, tells a different tale. "The earning from pisciculture is at least four times more than what a farmer earns from an equivalent plot of land. This is why farmers are shifting to fishing. Eighteen new water bodies have come up in Sabang," says panchayat samiti head Tapan Hazra.

According to a survey by the All India Krishak Sabha (AIKS), 20,000 hectares of land spread over East and West Midnapore, Howrah, North and South 24 Parganas districts have undergone a change of character. North and South 24 Parganas top the list, with 9,000 hectares and 4,000 hectares, respectively, of farmland converted to fish ponds. "The record identifies the land as agricultural plots. The conversion happens surreptitiously, sometimes on a tacit understanding between the buyer and seller," says AIKS state secretary Amal Haldar. For all the talk of farmers' income having increased threefold in Bengal, cultivators are opting out of farming, he adds.

That may be a trend, but can the beleaguered farmers in West Midnapore hope for any help from their chief minister, who sat on a 26-day hunger strike to protest the farmland grab in Singur for the Tata Motors factory? "She's beyond our reach. The men at the intermediate level are making it difficult for us to live," says a farmer who now works as a mason after his land was converted into a pond against his wish. ■